

GOODProjects Grant Draft

GOODProjects Foundation Grant Draft Morgan Stanley Alliance for Children’s Mental Health Innovation Awards (2027 cycle)

STATUS: Draft for Neo’s go/no-go review. Not yet submitted. Note: the dev bible’s “Who?” column lists this as “DM,” not “DD,” and someone (initials “MWP”) already attended the funder’s June 23 information session; check with them for anything learned there before finalizing.

SUPERSEDED FOR SUBMISSION PURPOSES: Morgan Stanley’s actual application is a structured web form with hard per-question character limits, not an open narrative. The submission-ready answer set, built directly against the real portal questions, is `2026-07-morgan-stanley-application-answers.md`. This document remains the source narrative and budget rationale; pull from it, but submit from the answer set, not from this file directly.

FUNDER & OPPORTUNITY DETAILS

Funder Name	Morgan Stanley Alliance for Children’s Mental Health
Program / Fund	Children’s Mental Health Innovation Awards (Innovation Awards category, \$100,000)
Ask Amount	\$100,000
Deadline	July 24, 2026, 11:59 pm ET (per internal grant tracker; confirmed as the correct 2027-cycle deadline via Morgan Stanley’s public program page)
Submission Portal	Online application at morganstanley.com/about-us/giving-back/childrens-mental-health-awards . Direct site access is not available from this environment; confirmed via public search results rather than a direct page load, so re-check the live portal before submission.
Contact	acmhinnovation@morganstanley.com (confirmed via Morgan Stanley’s public FAQ page)
GOODProjects Program Anchor	SW Peace Garden (trauma-informed programming), integrated with GOODZone’s Crisis Intervention Specialists and GOODLearningHub’s on-site mental health services

Funder Name	Morgan Stanley Alliance for Children’s Mental Health
Go/No-Go Confirmed	Not yet. Routing to Neo.

Eligibility requires U.S. 501(c)(3) status with annual total revenue under \$5 million. GOODProjects’ FY2025 revenue was \$1,694,903 (01-org-identity.md , 04-impact-data.md), well under the cap. There is also a separate “Next Gen Innovation Awards” category (\$25,000 to \$50,000) for organizations founded and/or led by someone under 32; this draft targets the standard Innovation Awards category instead, since Darius Baxter’s age likely places him outside that category’s eligibility window. Confirm before submission.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

GOODProjects requests \$100,000 from the Morgan Stanley Alliance for Children’s Mental Health Innovation Awards to scale the SW Peace Garden, a trauma-informed therapeutic horticulture program for youth and families in Southwest DC exposed to community violence and poverty. The Peace Garden treats healing as a community-built process rather than a clinical service alone, integrating directly with GOODProjects’ existing crisis response and mental health referral systems to reach youth who would not otherwise access care.

ORGANIZATIONAL OVERVIEW

GOODProjects is a Washington, DC nonprofit (founded 2016) working to end the cycle of intergenerational poverty through a place-based, two-generation model, pairing children’s education and youth development with the economic mobility, food security, health, and stability of the adults around them, so that progress in one generation reinforces the next. We serve residents of James Creek, Syphax Gardens, and Greenleaf, three public housing communities in Southwest DC’s Ward 6, where median household income is approximately \$14,000.

GOODProjects operates with a staff of 30 (11 full-time, 19 part-time) and 50 volunteers. The organization has invested more than \$8 million in Southwest DC since 2016. Our CEO Darius Baxter (Forbes 30 Under 30, 2023 Washingtonian of the Year) brings deep personal connection to the mission alongside executive leadership experience. Our FY2024 audit by Desai Company returned an unmodified opinion, signed September 7, 2025.

COMMUNITY NEED

Southwest DC’s Ward 6 public housing communities, James Creek, Syphax Gardens, and Greenleaf, are among the city’s most resource-constrained neighborhoods. Over the past six years, the GOODZone coverage area recorded 249 violent incidents, less than half the 601 recorded in the neighboring Navy Yard area, but violence exposure remains a persistent, present reality for the youth and families GOODProjects serves, not a resolved problem. Chronic exposure to community violence, combined with poverty and housing instability, produces sustained trauma that most children in these communities have no dedicated, non-clinical space to process. Southwest DC has no equivalent green, healing-centered space built specifically for this purpose outside of GOODProjects’ own Peace Garden.

PROJECT DESCRIPTION

Program Anchor

SW Peace Garden, GOODProjects' trauma-informed therapeutic horticulture program, is the anchor for this request. It operates on the premise that trauma is a public health issue and that healing happens through connection: to the earth, to nourishing food, to a supportive community, and to oneself. The Garden already has one funded track record: a \$5,000 award from Progressive Life Center/Building Blocks in 2022.

Target Population

GOODProjects serves Black families living in Ward 6 public housing, James Creek, Syphax Gardens, and Greenleaf. The Peace Garden serves youth and families across all program phases, with particular focus on youth ages 5 to 24 and their caregivers who have direct or secondary exposure to community violence.

Activities and Approach

The Peace Garden's programming operates across five pillars, all delivered through consistent, in-person sessions in a shared community garden space in Southwest DC:

1. **Therapeutic Horticulture & Somatic Engagement:** structured, age-appropriate gardening tasks (planting, watering, harvesting) that provide sensory regulation and model stability and growth.
2. **Social-Emotional Learning in Nature's Classroom:** facilitated circle time, cooperative projects, and conflict-resolution activities tied to garden care.
3. **Nutritional Empowerment & Food Justice Education:** cooking demonstrations and seed-to-table lessons addressing food access alongside mental health.
4. **Safe Haven & Pro-Social Community Building:** consistent after-school and weekend programming in a physically and psychologically safe space.
5. **Intergenerational Healing & Family Engagement:** family harvest days and caregiver workshops that extend healing to the whole household, not just the enrolled youth.

This request would fund a dedicated Peace Garden Program Coordinator, expanded weekly programming hours, and formal integration with GOODZone's Crisis Intervention Specialists, so that any youth stabilized after a violent incident has a same-week warm handoff into ongoing, non-clinical trauma support at the Garden rather than a one-time crisis response alone.

Timeline

Month 1-2	Hire and onboard a dedicated Peace Garden Program Coordinator; formalize the GOODZone-to-Peace-Garden referral pathway
Month 3-4	Expand weekly programming hours; begin family harvest day series
Month 5-8	Full operating cadence across all five program pillars; mid-year data review
Month 9-12	Second family harvest day series; year-end evaluation and report

OUTCOMES AND EVALUATION

GOODProjects tracks participation and outcomes across all programs using Salesforce CRM and program-specific data tools.

Committed Outcomes for This Grant

Output	75 youth and family participants enrolled in expanded Peace Garden programming in Year 1, a projected caseload for one dedicated full-time Program Coordinator running weekly sessions plus two family harvest day series
Short-term	Reduced self-reported anxiety and stress symptoms, measured through pre/post participant surveys
Medium-term	Increased sense of safety and belonging, and improved emotional regulation, measured through staff observation and quarterly check-ins
Long-term	Sustained family engagement across multiple garden seasons, and reduced referral-to-engagement time between a GOODZone crisis response and a youth's first Peace Garden session

NOTE: this is a projected Year 1 target for new, expanded programming, not a historical figure. The Peace Garden does not yet have the same depth of tracked historical metrics as GOODZone, FSP, or GOODLearningHub. Confirm the 75-participant target is realistic with Stephanie Page-Baxter or Marquel Webb before submission; adjust if their read on coordinator caseload capacity differs.

EQUITY STATEMENT

We operate on the principle that economic mobility requires addressing both skills gaps and systemic barriers simultaneously. We practice equity by eliminating barriers rather than asking people to overcome them. Our hiring, programming, and partnerships prioritize those with lived experience of the challenges we address. We actively recruit staff and board members from the communities we serve, recognizing that proximity to the problem creates proximity to the solution. We do not design programs for communities; we design them with communities.

ORGANIZATIONAL CAPACITY

Key Personnel

Name	Role
Darius Baxter	Founder & CEO / Authorized Signatory
Demetruis Baxter	Chief of Staff
Stephanie Page-Baxter	Director of Youth Programming

Name	Role
Neo Mangope	Fundraising & Grants Officer
Marquel Webb	FSP Lead
Phileke Holland	Afterschool Lead / Youth Program Coordinator
Cole Bradshaw	Finance & Operations
Melissa	Reporting & Stewardship

Partnerships

GOODProjects’ key implementation partners include Amidon-Bowen Elementary School, DC Department of Employment Services (DOES), DC Department of Parks and Recreation (DPR), Southwest Business Improvement District (SWBID), C3 Wellness (mental health services), CityTutor DC, and DC Central Kitchen. C3 Wellness in particular already provides trauma-informed care and wellness check-ins across GOODProjects’ continuum and would be a natural referral partner for the Peace Garden’s expansion.

Financial Health

Our FY2024 audit was conducted by Desai Company and returned an unmodified opinion (signed September 7, 2025). EIN: 81-1491594.

BUDGET NARRATIVE

Total request: \$100,000 for a 12-month program period.

The Peace Garden does not have an established annual budget on file the way GOODZone, FSP, and GOODSports do, so this is the program’s first proposed dedicated budget. Personnel is sized against comparable GOODProjects coordinator-level roles; fringe (22%) and indirect (10% of MTDC) match the rates already documented and used in GOODZone’s FY2025-2026 budget and the OVSJG-funded budget on file, not invented figures. Cole should still confirm the final numbers before submission, but the structure below reconciles exactly to the \$100,000 ask.

Personnel	Peace Garden Program Coordinator, 1.0 FTE	\$55,000
Fringe	22% of personnel, matching GOODZone’s documented rate	\$12,100
Program Supplies	Therapeutic horticulture materials, garden tools, cooking demonstration supplies	\$12,000
Participant Costs	Family harvest day events, transportation for family engagement sessions	\$7,810
Evaluation	Pre/post survey design and outcome tracking, consistent with GOODZone’s evaluation model	\$4,000

Personnel	Peace Garden Program Coordinator, 1.0 FTE	\$55,000
Subtotal, direct costs		\$90,910
Indirect	10% of MTDC, matching GOODProjects' standard rate	\$9,090
TOTAL		\$100,000

SUSTAINABILITY

GOODProjects does not depend on single-source funding. Our diversified revenue base includes DC government grants (ONSE, DPR, OVSJG), national foundation grants (Ford Foundation, Robert Wood Johnson Foundation), and corporate and individual giving. If awarded, this grant would establish the Peace Garden's first dedicated program budget, positioned to attract future funding once its outcomes are tracked with the same rigor as GOODProjects' other three continuum phases.

GOODProjects, Inc. | 996 Maine Avenue SW, Suite 208, Washington, DC 20024 | EIN 81-1491594 | grants@goodprojects.org